

Chapter 18-2

Everyone begins their secondary gender differentiation¹ between ages 15-18.

Before age 15, no one knows what gender they will become.

Even so, many people still experience romantic stirrings before age 15.

In middle school, when a girl that Liang Shi liked gave Zhao Xuning a love letter, Liang Shi cornered Zhao Xuning after school with some people.

The two even arranged a fight.

That day both of them got injured, but Zhao Xuning came out ahead, and from then on Liang Shi never bothered Zhao Xuning again.

Zhao Xuning had always looked down on Liang Shi.

Or rather, she looked down on those second-generation rich kids who acted recklessly just because their families had money.

So Zhou Yi'an was also within her scope of dislike.

"But she is indeed very different from before," Zhao Xuning said honestly. "She suddenly became polite, modest, gentle, and even has some affinity."

After a moment of silence, Xu Qingzhu said, "Is there a possibility that this isn't Liang Shi?"

"I've considered that, but I checked all the surveillance footage since she was admitted to the hospital, and also verified her blood type and DNA. Everything proves that she is Liang Shi."

"What other reasons could cause her to change her personality overnight?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"Have there been similar cases before?"

"There have been some before. Some were transferred to national secret organizations for research and were detained for decades. Others were later proven to have simply made heartfelt changes, but generally they were all stimulated by major events." Zhao Xuning paused. "Which type do you think she belongs to?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I'm not sure."

After a moment, Xu Qingzhu thought of something: "That day during my heat period, when she wanted to forcibly mark me, I pushed her hard and her head hit the wall with a particularly loud sound. Could it be related to that?"

"It's possible, but I checked and there's no blood clot compressing her nerves, so it doesn't seem like amnesia. But it could be caused by other factors." Zhao Xuning said, "I'll give her a full body examination tomorrow."

"Will she agree to it?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Zhao Xuning's hand, which had been turning her glasses, suddenly stopped, and she said firmly: "The current her will."

"But..." Zhao Xuning paused. "Isn't the current her good?"

"Very good, so good it's unbelievable," Xu Qingzhu said.

"So why bother about it?" Zhao Xuning said. "Whether she's a prodigal son who's reformed or had an awakening, as long as she's good enough now, isn't that fine? Sometimes people can't be too obsessed with answers."

Xu Qingzhu suddenly smiled. "You're right."

After Zhao Xuning left, Xu Qingzhu lay in bed thinking.

After a long while, she sent Liang Shi a message: 【I lost my composure earlier, sorry.】

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Liang Shi only saw the text message when she woke up the next day. She replied: 【It's fine.】

Then she went downstairs to buy breakfast and brought it to the tenth floor to eat with Xu Qingzhu.

The two had a very quiet breakfast.

Liang Shi didn't think about bringing up divorce either.

She had already tried - sending divorce-related messages to Xu Qingzhu would be blocked by the system, and yesterday the system had briefly appeared to warn her not to do futile work anymore.

There were no shortcuts to conquest.

She gave up.

After breakfast, Liang Shi politely declined Zhao Xuning's suggestion for a full body examination, insisted on processing her own discharge, and asked Xu Qingzhu if she wanted to be discharged too.

Zhao Xuning happened to come by and said discharge was possible, but she would need to rest quietly at home and could only resume normal activities after careful observation for two days.

So Liang Shi processed her discharge procedures as well.

On the way home, Xu Qingzhu sat in the passenger seat without saying a word the entire journey, returning to that aloof appearance that kept strangers at bay.

Last night's vulnerability and distance seemed to have completely vanished.

The two were like strangers.

As the car was driving near Yunding Tower², Liang Shi's phone suddenly rang.

The soothing light music made Xu Qingzhu open her eyes. She looked at Liang Shi who was driving. "Pull over or should I hang up for you?"

Liang Shi said: "Check who it is first."

She didn't dare to suddenly let Xu Qingzhu answer.

The original owner's phone was like a ticking time bomb - you never knew when it would explode.

She was already nervous answering it herself, let alone having Xu Qingzhu answer.

Xu Qingzhu glanced at it - it was Xu Qingya.

Only then did she answer and put it on speaker.

Xu Qingya said on the phone: "Sister Liang Shi, what are you doing? Let's discuss something."

Liang Shi looked at Xu Qingzhu, who just mouthed: "Drive properly."

Liang Shi coughed lightly and tried to sound normal: "What is it?"

"The hotel is too lonely," Xu Qingya said. "Can I stay at your house for a few days?"

Xu Qingzhu decisively refused: "No."

"Ah? My sister is there too?" Xu Qingya was somewhat annoyed, then said: "I'm asking Sister Liang Shi, not you."

"I have the final say," Xu Qingzhu said.

Xu Qingya snorted coldly: "I'm going anyway. I'm already at your front door. Come back quickly."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Liang Shi had no choice but to say: "Then wait a moment. Your sister and I will be there soon."

After hanging up, Xu Qingzhu said: "I'll handle my sister's affairs, you don't need to worry. When we get back, I'll move to the easternmost room on the first floor and pay you rent at market rate. My father is in poor health and the company has some problems now, so I can't divorce you temporarily. But when the right time comes, we'll go get divorced, okay?"

Before Liang Shi could respond, Xu Qingzhu continued: "During this time, I hope you can act the same as before in front of my family members. Act if you can."

Liang Shi: "....."

Footnotes:

¹ Secondary gender differentiation (分化): In ABO dynamics, this refers to when individuals develop their Alpha, Beta, or Omega characteristics during puberty.

² Yunding Tower (雲頂大廈): A high-end residential building where Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu live.

